Some US-based commentators seem to believe that it is possible to deal with Myanmar's army as a military institution separate from one that is involved in politics and controls the riches of the country.[25] But the problem is that the military does have a virtual monopoly on the resources of the country, and any riches to be gained from developing or exploiting these resources will end up flowing to the generals and their group of cronies, regardless of changes in the electoral process.[26] Thus, any wishful thinking about the gains that the whole of society might make from foreign investment comes at a time when there is growing doubt that the military has any intention of 'withdrawing from politics',[27] let alone from the commanding heights of the Myanmar economy.

More generally, there is evidence of an intra-military dispute about the reform process and this seems to be affecting both the stability of the USDP and its interaction with the NLD. In late 2013, the USDP—in effect the old military regime dressed up as a political party—indicated that it supported repealing the clause in the constitution that bars Aung San Suu Kyi from being president on the basis that she married a foreigner.[28] But by late 2014 it had changed its view and was now supporting the continuation of this ban. One possible reason for these shifts is growing discontent with President Thein Sein among the older officers, as supporters of the ousted Than Shwe seek a return to power.[29] If so, this is better seen as a dispute as to the best way to secure continued military control over the country's wealth than a dispute than about the transition to greater democracy, especially as the military leaders have argued that the NLD is not ready to take power.[30] In addition, since 2014, Aung San Suu Kyi's previously good relationship with Thein Sein has broken down[31] as the NLD has become more of an electoral threat. As this book goes to press, they are involved in negotiating a transfer of power in the parliament from the USDP to the NLD.

By 2014, there was evidence that the move to democracy was stalled, that Thein Sein was tightening his grip on power and was driving his rivals from positions of influence. These tensions were particularly evident in the relationship between the USDP and the NLD in the run up to the November 2015 elections. In mid-August, Shwe Mann, the USDP party chairman and speaker of the parliament, was briefly arrested and removed from his post.[32] Various theories have been put forward as to why this happened, including